

Myth and reality
Viking mythology is full of tales of heroic warriors, such as Sigurd, seen here in a 12th-century woodcarving, slaying the dragon Fafnir with his magic sword *(above)*. The day-to-day weapon of the Vikings was the sax *(right)*,a knife that doubled as a short sword if trouble arose.

VIKING WARRIORS FROM SCANDINAVIA first appeared in documented history in the late 8th century as seafaring raiders terrorizing the population of coasts and islands around Western Europe. Over time, raids expanded into campaigns of conquest and permanent settlement. Vikings voyaged as far as North America and, via Russian rivers, to the Black Sea. Although the excellence of their long ships and the boldness of their maritime enterprise was the key to their success, they were also formidable fighters on land.

Why the agricultural and fishing communities of Scandinavia should have suddenly generated a plague of raiders to prey upon the kingdoms of Anglo-Saxon England and the Frankish Empire is not known for certain. The most likely explanation is that in overpopulated coastal communities only the eldest son inherited his father's possessions, so younger siblings, with no means of making a living locally, sought fame and fortune overseas. The first raiding forces would have consisted of perhaps a couple of ships from two neighbouring villages setting off in search of trade goods – silver and slaves seem to have been particularly desirable commodities. As few as 40 armed men could easily have overwhelmed an English coastal village or isolated monastery. The Anglo-Saxon invasion of England in the 5th century CE had begun in very much the same way, with small raiding parties developing into much larger invasion forces.

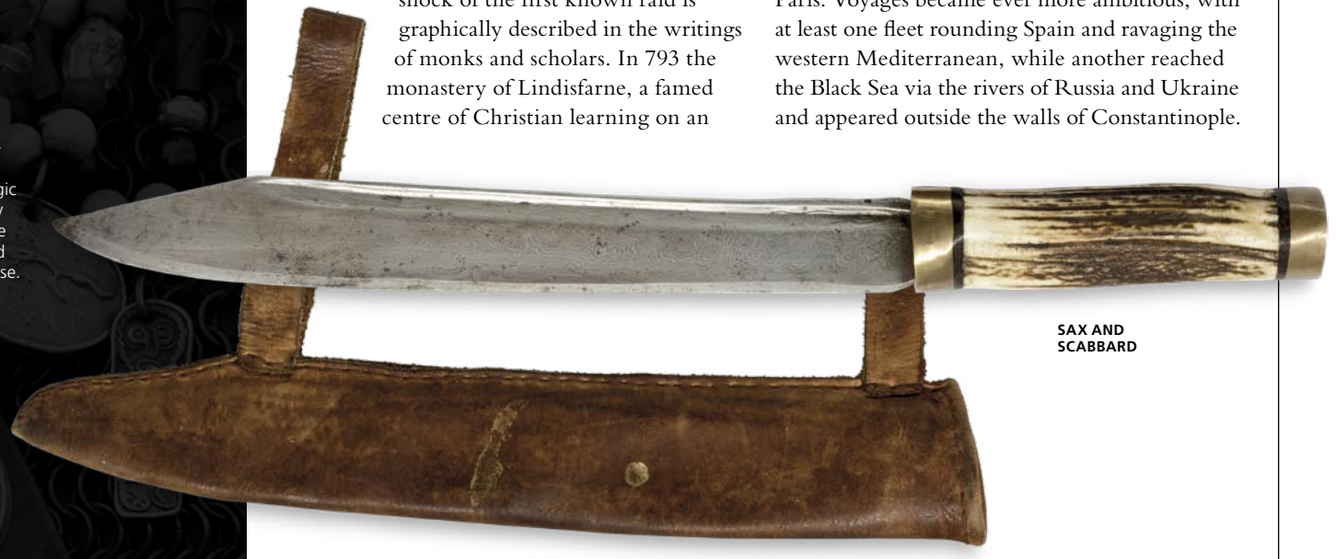
The first recorded Viking landing in England probably took place in 787, but, although blood was shed, it did not develop into a raid. The shock of the first known raid is graphically described in the writings of monks and scholars. In 793 the monastery of Lindisfarne, a famed centre of Christian learning on an island off the Northumbrian coast, was sacked by Vikings in a raid of sensational suddenness and violence. The scholar Alcuin wrote, in a letter to Northumbria's King Ethelred, "never before has such terror appeared as we have now suffered from a pagan race". A later chronicler, Simeon of Durham, described how the raiders killed some monks, carried others off "in fetters", and looted the monastery of its considerable treasures. Departing for Norway with a hoard of gold and silver plate, and with prisoners for sale as slaves, the Vikings presumably viewed the raid as a great success.



Swedish Viking pendant
Silver looted on Viking raids was often melted down and turned into personal jewellery.

EXPANDING HORIZONS

Raiding was sporadic and small-scale until the 830s – hit-and-run attacks more akin to piracy than warfare. But then Danish Vikings began to mount more substantial operations against southern England, the Low Countries, and the coast of France. Antwerp, for example, was laid waste in 836 and Nantes in 843. In 845 a warrior called Ragnar led a fleet of ships up the river Seine, drove off a Frankish army and sacked Paris. Voyages became ever more ambitious, with at least one fleet rounding Spain and ravaging the western Mediterranean, while another reached the Black Sea via the rivers of Russia and Ukraine and appeared outside the walls of Constantinople.



SAX AND SCABBARD